

Syllabus

Rhetoric: Persuasion in Reading, Writing, and Critical Thinking

In this course, students become rhetorical masters of persuasion and argumentation. By the end of the year, students will have engaged in local government, pitched a Super Bowl commercial, solved a mystery through rational evidence-building, and devised a plan for sharing a limited global resource. By tackling these challenging, engaging projects, students develop a deep understanding of how they can wield the tools of rhetoric to persuade others—and how they can recognize the rhetorical strategies at work in the world around them.

The goal of AoPS Academy Language Arts courses is to train the intellectual leaders of the next generation by fostering creative problem solving. In our classes, students tackle projects that are framed as interpretation and communication problems: how can we communicate an idea in just the right way? Or, how can we understand complex ideas that are being communicated to us? To solve these problems, students must craft written pieces and oral presentations that demonstrate mastery of the Language Arts skills they learned in class. In this way, our courses help students develop the confidence and advanced literacy skills they need to solve any communication problem they encounter, whether it's in college, in the professional world, or in their own lives.

Time Commitment: This 36-week course includes 105 minutes in-class and 60-90 minutes of homework each week, corresponding to a full year course.

Homework: Students should expect to spend about 1-2 hours on homework every week. Homework will include: practicing skills learned in class through questions in the course homepage, long-term writing assignments connected to the unit project, and assigned reading in one of the quarterly textbooks.

Content:

Week	Topic	Week	Topic
1	The Rhetorical Situation	19	The Game Is Afoot
2	The Audience	20	Forming a Hypothesis
3	The Speaker	21	Collecting Evidence
4	The Occasion	22	Eliminating the Impossible
5	Purpose and Planning	23	Prove beyond a Reasonable Doubt
6	Arrangement	24	A Tale of Two Audiences
7	Argument and Enthymeme	25	Pathos, Judgment, and Imagery
8	How to Have a Conversation	26	Revision and Oratory
9	The Town Council Meeting	27	Cracking the Case
10	Introduction to Rhetoric in Advertising	28	Argument Structure
11	Pathos in Advertising	29	Negotiation
12	Ethos in Advertising	30	Speaking from a Script
13	Logos in Advertising	31	Rhetorical Fallacies
14	Exigence	32	How to Win an Argument
15	Kairos and Decorum	33	Rhetorical Analysis
16	Peer Review	34	Formal Debate
17	Revision	35	Peer Review and Rehearsal
18	Commercial Pitches	36	The United Nations Summit

The course is divided into four project-based units:

Unit	Description	Common Core Standards	Core Skills or Concepts
1 Rhetoric Fundamentals	Using a framework originally developed by classical rhetoricians, students build a strong foundation for rhetorical mastery as they write a speech to sway a town council's vote. Book: none	RIT 7.1, 7.2, 7.8, 8.1, W 7.1.A, 7.1.E, 7.2.A, 7.2.B, 7.2.C, 7.4, 7.5, 7.10, 8.1.A, 8.1.E, 8.2.A, 8.2.B, 8.2.C, 8.4, 8.5, 8.10, 9-10.1.E, 9-10.2.C, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.10 SL 7.1.B, 7.1.C, 7.1.D, 7.6, 8.1.B, 8.1.C, 8.1.D, 8.6, 9-10.1.B, 9-10.1.C, 9-10.1.D, 9-10.6	The rhetorical situation; Aristotelian theory; close reading; audience analysis; context analysis; speech and argument structure; peer review; revision.
2 Marketing	Students deepen their understanding of persuasive techniques by studying successful marketing strategies, all while preparing to pitch a commercial for a fictional business. Book: <i>Contagious</i>	W 7.1.B, 7.2.B, 7.2.D, 7.4, 7.5, 7.6, 7.10, 8.1.B, 8.2.B, 8.2.D, 8.4, 8.5, 8.6, 8.10, 9-10.2.B, 9-10.2.D, 9-10.4, 9-10.6, 9-10.10 SL 7.4, 8.4, 9-10.4	Analyzing an advertisement using logos, ethos, and pathos; analyzing the context of an advertisement; using a writing style that is appropriate to a subject, situation, speaker, and audience; peer review and revision; writing an advertisement; delivering a pitch.
3 Literary Mystery	Students are immersed in a fictional mystery as they learn how to build a strong body of evidence and solve the case through advanced literary and rhetorical analysis. Book: <i>Murder Is Bad Manners</i>	RL 7.1, 8.1, 8.3, 9-10.1, 9-10.3 W 7.1.A-B, 7.3.A-B, 7.3D, 7.4, 7.5, 7.6, 7.9, 7.10, 8.1.A-B, 8.3A, 8.3B, 8.3D, 8.4, 8.5, 8.6, 8.9, 8.10, 9-10.1.A-B, 9-10.3.A-B, 9-10.3D, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.6, 9-10.9, 9-10.10	Organizing textual details; forming and evaluating hypotheses; collecting textual evidence; drawing inferences; critical reading; writing for an audience; using logos, ethos, and pathos; using sensory details in writing; creative writing; drafting and revision.
4 Global Problem Solving	Students develop their rhetorical skills on a global stage as they convene in a simulated United Nations to argue for the best way to distribute a limited natural resource. Book: <i>Getting to Yes</i>	W 7.1.A-B, 7.1.D-E, 7.4, 7.5, 7.6, 7.7, 7.10, 8.1.A-B, 8.1.D-E, 8.4, 8.5, 8.6, 8.10, 9-10.1.A-B, 9-10.1.D-E, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.6, 9-10.10 SL 7.1.A, 7.1.C, 7.1.D, 7.3, 7.4, 8.1.A, 8.1.C, 8.1.D, 8.3, 8.4, 9-10.1.A, 9-10.4	Persuading an adversarial audience; analyzing international relationships; structuring an argument according to claim, evidence, and impact; negotiation; rhetorical fallacies; rhetorical analysis; debate; peer review; speech delivery.

To interpret the Common Core Standards column on the table above, visit the Common Core ELA website at www.corestandards.org/ELA-Literacy.